

PayPal payment plans — walkthrough

Everything I would have covered on a call, written down so you can re-read it, forward it, and hold me to it.

You asked for PayPal subscriptions. Once you described what you actually wanted — *set the number of months a client should pay the remaining balance, they choose 3, 4 or 6, then their account gets charged monthly* — that turned out to be a different product. So there are two halves here, and the instalment half is the bigger one.

Payment plans — the main thing

Your staff enter what a customer owes and which lengths to offer. The customer opens a link, picks one, and PayPal takes it monthly until the balance is clear, then stops by itself.

Subscription plans — the second half

Ordinary recurring plans, monthly or yearly, at any rate you like, created from wp-admin without touching config files.

1. What your customer sees

One link per customer. No account, no login, nothing to install. The figures on the cards are the real amounts that will be charged — not "from \$x".

INV-1042

Balance to pay

1000.00 USD

Choose how long you would like to pay over

3 monthly payments

☒ **333.33 USD per month**

first payment 333.34 USD

total 1000.00 USD — no extra charge

4 monthly payments

☐ **250.00 USD per month**

total 1000.00 USD — no extra charge

6 monthly payments

☐ **166.66 USD per month**

first payment 166.70 USD

total 1000.00 USD — no extra charge

Continue to PayPal

Nothing is charged until you approve it at PayPal. Payments then run automatically and stop by themselves once the balance is clear.

A \$1,000 balance offered over 3, 4 or 6 months. Note the 3-month option: 333.34 first, then 333.33 twice. A balance rarely divides evenly, and the odd cent has to go somewhere — see section 6.

They approve at PayPal once. After that the page turns into a progress view, and there is nothing left for them to click:

INV-1042

Balance to pay

750.00 USD

250.00 USD of 1000.00 USD already paid

1 of 3 payments made

2 to go, 750.00 USD remaining. Payments are taken automatically —
there is nothing you need to do.

The same link, later. The count comes from payments that actually cleared, not from the calendar — a failed charge must not read as paid.

2. Invoice first, deposit, then the plan

You said you invoice each customer separately, that some pay a deposit and carry a larger remaining balance, and that you want the plan set up *after* the invoice goes out. That is exactly the shape this takes. There is no price list anywhere in it — every customer is quoted on their own.

- 1 **Invoice them however you already do.** Nothing here sends invoices, and nothing here needs to change about how you raise them.
- 2 **Take the deposit however you already take it.** Cash, transfer, card, a PayPal payment — it does not matter, because that money never passes through this.
- 3 **Balance owed** = the invoice total *minus* the deposit. This is the only figure PayPal ever charges.
- 4 **Deposit already paid** = what you took, for the record. It is stored against the plan and shown on both screens, and it is *never charged again*.
- 5 **Reference** = your invoice number, so their page and their invoice carry the same one.

So a \$1,340 invoice with a \$500 deposit is entered as balance 840.00, deposit 500.00. Here is what that customer opens:

INV-1042

Balance to pay

840.00 USD

1340.00 USD invoiced, less the 500.00 USD deposit you have already paid

Choose how long you would like to pay over

3 monthly payments

☒ **280.00 USD per month**

total 840.00 USD — no extra charge

4 monthly payments

☐ **210.00 USD per month**

total 840.00 USD — no extra charge

6 monthly payments

☐ **140.00 USD per month**

total 840.00 USD — no extra charge

Continue to PayPal

Nothing is charged until you approve it at PayPal. Payments then run automatically and stop by themselves once the balance is clear.

Without that second line the customer sees 840 where their invoice said 1,340, and rings you up. The deposit line is there to stop that call.

The one mistake this form lets you make. Typing the *invoice total* into Balance owed while *also* filling in the deposit charges the customer for money they have already handed over. Nothing can detect that from the outside — both numbers are perfectly legitimate — so instead the confirmation reads the arithmetic back at you:

840.00 USD will be split into monthly payments – invoice 1340.00 USD less the 500.00 USD deposit already received.

Read that line before you send the link. It is the only guard there can be.

A deposit is not a first instalment. If you would rather PayPal collected the deposit as part of the plan, do not use that field — put the whole balance on the plan and let the first payment be the deposit.

Two things worth being straight about

Nothing here raises or sends the invoice. If you want PayPal to issue the invoice too — created and emailed from this same screen, then the plan opened for whatever is left — that is a real addition rather than a setting, and I would rather scope it properly than pretend it is already there. Say the word and I will.

"Withdraw from their account" needs one click from them, once. PayPal will not let anyone — me, you, or itself — start pulling money from a customer without that customer approving it first. They approve the plan once, and from then on PayPal takes each month automatically with nothing further from them. That first approval is not something I can remove, and you would not want a payments provider that let me.

3. What you see

A **PayPal** menu appears in wp-admin with three screens.

Payment Plans

Payment plans

New payment plan

Customer

Passed to PayPal to prefill their checkout. Optional.

Reference

Your invoice or job number. Shown to the customer, so their invoice and this page match.

Balance owed

USD

The amount to be charged in instalments — the invoice total *after* deducting any deposit. Split evenly across the months they choose; no interest, no fee.

Deposit already paid

USD

Optional, and for the record only. This money has already reached you by some other means, so it is **never charged again**. It is shown to the customer purely so the figure on their page reconciles with the invoice you sent them.

Payment lengths to offer

☒ 3 months ☒ 4 months ☒ 6 months

Tick one to fix the term yourself; tick several to let the customer choose.

Internal note

Staff only — never shown to the customer.

Create payment plan

Settings

Currency

Must match the currency the template plans were created in. Changing it means re-running setup.

Default lengths

Comma separated, e.g. `3,4,6`. Pre-ticked on the form above.

Customer page

The page containing the `[paypal_payment_plan]` shortcode. Customer links point here.

Brand name

Shown on the PayPal approval screen.

Template plans

3 months = P-3XA92117KH2094521MZQ2R4A, 4 months = P-7BL41903VD1937243MZQ2SLI, 6 months = P-9CK50882PS0284618MZQ2TDY

Save settings

Sync template plans from setup

Existing plans

Ref	Customer	Balance	Paid	Term	Status	Created	
INV-2291	Marcus Bell	840.00 USD	0.00	3/4/6 offered	offered	2026-09-05 08:40:11	View
INV-2287	Priya Raman	1000.00 USD	333.34	3 months	active	2026-08-28 14:02:55	View
INV-2260	Dale Ferreira	600.00 USD	600.00	4 months	completed	2026-05-02 10:20:00	View

Create a customer's plan, set the site-wide defaults, and see every plan you have issued. Tick one length to fix it yourself; tick several to let the customer choose.

One customer, in detail

Payment plans

- all payment plans

Reference	INV-2287
Customer	Priya Raman priya.raman@example.com
Balance on the plan	1000.00 USD
Paid to date	333.34 USD <i>(666.66 USD still to pay)</i>
Status	active
Term	3 monthly payments
Subscription	I-BW452GLLEP1G
Customer link	https://northgatestudio.com/pay-your-balance/?ref=4b4b4b4b4b4b4b4b4b4b4b4b4b4b4b4b. Send this to the customer. Anyone holding it can set up the plan, so treat it like an invoice link.

Schedule

Payment 1	333.34 USD
Payment 2	333.33 USD
Payment 3	333.33 USD

Payments received

When	Amount	Status	PayPal sale
2026-08-28 14:06:31	333.34 USD	completed	3XW28517LA4402910

Cancel this payment plan

What they owe, what has arrived, the exact schedule, and the link to send them. Every payment is logged against PayPal's own sale id.

The same screen, with a deposit on it

Payment plans

- all payment plans

Reference	INV-2291
Customer	Marcus Bell marcus.bell@example.com
Invoice total	1340.00 USD <i>(less 500.00 USD deposit already received)</i>
Balance on the plan	840.00 USD
Paid to date	0.00 USD <i>(840.00 USD still to pay)</i>
Status	offered
Term	not chosen yet — offered 3, 4, 6
Subscription	-
Customer link	https://northgatestudio.com/pay-your-balance/?ref=7c7c7c7c7c7c7c7c7c7c7c7c7c7c7c7c Send this to the customer. Anyone holding it can set up the plan, so treat it like an invoice link.
Note	Kitchen fit-out, second half.

Payments received

Nothing yet. Charges appear here as PayPal reports them, not when they are due.

[Cancel this payment plan](#)

Invoice total, the deposit that came off it, and the figure PayPal will actually collect — kept as three separate lines so nobody has to do the subtraction in their head to check it.

Subscription Plans

Subscription plans

Environment: **sandbox** . Plans created here exist only in this environment — sandbox plans are not visible to live customers and vice versa.

Key	Name	Price	Billing	Length	Trial	Status	Plan ID	Actions
gold-monthly	Gold membership — monthly	29.99 USD	every month	until cancelled	14 days free	ACTIVE	P-2VC77034HA9052618MZQ2UAA	29.99 Reprice Retire Remove
gold-annual	Gold membership — yearly	299.00 USD	every year	until cancelled	—	ACTIVE	P-8RD21965BB4471502MZQ2UQQ	299.00 Reprice Retire Remove
starter-monthly	Starter — monthly	9.00 USD	every month	12 payments	—	INACTIVE	P-5TH60441WU8823019MZQ2VBQ	9.00 Reprice Re-list Remove

Add a plan

Key

Short, lowercase, permanent. This is what your theme and the REST calls use.

Name

Shown to the customer at PayPal. Cannot be changed later.

Price

Billed

Fixed at creation. A monthly and a yearly rate are two separate plans — that is normal, and switching a customer between them is one call.

Number of payments

0 means bill until cancelled. Any other number stops the subscription after that many charges.

Free trial

days

0 for none. The first charge happens after the trial.

Joining fee

One-off, taken with the first payment. Leave blank for none.

Product name

The catalogue entry all your plans sit under. Created once; leave it alone after the first plan.

Create plan in PayPal

Monthly or yearly, any rate, optional free trial and joining fee. There is deliberately no Delete button — PayPal has no delete, and pretending otherwise would lie to you. Retire stops new sign-ups and leaves existing subscribers billing.

Status & Log

PayPal Subscriptions

Configuration

Environment	sandbox
Client ID	missing
Webhook ID	missing — every webhook will be rejected
Webhook URL	https://northgatestudio.com/wp-json/paypal-subs/v1/webhook
Subscription plans	gold-monthly — 29.99 USD every month, P-2VC77034HA9052618MZQ2UAA gold-annual — 299.00 USD every year, P-8RD219658B4471502MZQ2UQQ starter-monthly — 9.00 USD every month, P-5TH60441WU8823019MZQ2VBQ (not on sale)
Payment plan terms	3 months, 4 months, 6 months
Customer page	https://northgatestudio.com/pay-your-balance/

Recent events

Nothing yet. Register the webhook URL above in the PayPal developer dashboard.

Where you check the plumbing. Right now it says *missing* because it has never been pointed at a PayPal account — that is section 4.

4. Getting it live

Six steps. The badge says who does each one.

- 1 Create the PayPal app** **YOU**
In your PayPal Developer account, create an app and copy the **sandbox** client ID and secret. I cannot do this — I do not log into websites or dashboards, and it suits your own requirement that the app lives under your account rather than mine.
- 2 Send me those two values, plus your site's https address** **YOU**
Send them in the Freelancer chat. Sandbox credentials cannot move real money, so there is nothing at risk at this stage. Live credentials come later and separately.
- 3 Run the sandbox end to end and send you the log** **ME**
Create the plans, register the webhook, run a real payment plan through PayPal's sandbox, and send you the log showing every action and the webhook each one fired. You see it working before anything touches your site.

Risk here: none. Sandbox is a separate world — sandbox plans are invisible to live customers and vice versa.

4 Install on your site ME

The plugin folder goes in, the two credentials go in `wp-config.php` — not the database, because database exports get emailed around and a client secret in one is a live key in a spreadsheet. Then one page with the shortcode `[paypal_payment_plan]` on it.

Risk here: low, and reversible. Nothing existing is modified; deactivating the plugin returns the site to exactly where it was.

5 You test it yourself, still in sandbox YOU

Issue yourself a plan, click through it as a customer, watch the payments land on the detail screen. Nothing goes live until you say this looks right.

6 Switch to live ME

Live credentials, one setting changed, setup re-run to create the live plans, and the webhook re-registered against live. Sandbox history stays where it is and never mixes with real money.

Risk here: this is the one that matters — real cards. Which is why steps 3 and 5 exist.

5. What I need from you

- Sandbox **client ID** and **secret** from your PayPal Developer account
- Your site's **https address**, so the webhook can be registered against it
- An answer to the pricing question in section 6
- Later, once you are happy: the live client ID and secret, and FTP or file access to the site

I do not need, and will not ask for, your PayPal account login or your WordPress admin password.

6. The one decision I need from you

Should a longer plan cost more?

Right now it does not. \$1,000 costs \$1,000 whether the customer takes 3 months or 6, and the page says *"no extra charge"* on every option. That is a real business decision and I am not going to invent a markup on your behalf.

If you want longer terms priced higher — interest, an admin fee, whatever — tell me the numbers and it is a small change. My only strong opinion: it must be shown on the customer's screen, not buried in the arithmetic.

Why the odd cent moves

\$1,000 over 3 months is 333.33 recurring. Somebody has to absorb the cent. It goes on the **first** payment — 333.34, then 333.33, then 333.33 — never the last. If it went last, a customer who cancels part-way through is left with a closing figure that matches nothing anyone quoted them.

Balance	Term	First payment	Then	Total
1,200.00	3	400.00	2×400.00	1,200.00
1,000.00	3	333.34	2×333.33	1,000.00
1,000.00	4	250.00	3×250.00	1,000.00
1,000.00	6	166.70	5×166.66	1,000.00

7. What this does not do

- **It does not chase a debt.** Cancelling a plan stops PayPal charging; the outstanding balance stays on record so a human can follow it up. Nothing here sends demand letters.

- **It does not change a plan mid-flight.** PayPal freezes a plan's schedule once a customer approves it. Changing someone's balance means cancelling and issuing a new plan for the remainder.
 - **It does not take cards directly.** Everything goes through PayPal checkout. No card details ever touch your site, which is the point.
 - **It is not a credit check.** If a customer's card fails, PayPal retries and the plan is flagged `payment_failed` on your screen. Deciding what to do about that is yours.
 - **It does not do partial refunds automatically.** A refund issued in PayPal is recorded here and the paid-to-date recalculated, but the balance is not re-spread across the remaining months.
 - **No design work is included.** The customer page inherits your theme's fonts and colours rather than imposing its own.
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8. How I have proved it works so far

Everything above was built before any PayPal credentials existed, so it has been verified the ways that do not need an account:

- **212 automated checks**, no network needed — 146 on the library, 66 on the WordPress side.
- The screenshots on this page are the **real screens**, rendered from the actual plugin code against WordPress's own admin stylesheets. They are not mock-ups, so they cannot flatter the thing they show.
- **Mutation testing.** I break the code on purpose and check the tests notice. One break survived: making the quote ignore the chosen term, so every option showed the 3-month price. All the tests still passed, because the only figure I had asserted was the total — which is identical across terms by design. That is exactly the bug a customer would have seen. Assertions rewritten; that break now fails four checks.
- The deposit work above got the same treatment. I broke it six ways — the deposit dropped on save, added to the balance instead of subtracted from it, an unreadable figure silently rounded to zero, and so on. One of the six *survived*: nothing tested the path where staff actually type a deposit in, because every test read arrangements that already existed. Six more checks now drive the form itself, and all six breaks are caught.

- Reading those screenshots caught three real faults that no test was looking for: a running plan that greeted the customer with "your payment plan is set up" on every visit for six months, a destructive Cancel button styled identically to a harmless one, and a settings screen dumping raw JSON at you.

The one that would have cost you money. PayPal lets you override a plan's prices per customer — that is what makes one reusable plan work for every balance. If PayPal ever ignores that override it does *not* return an error. It creates the subscription, hands back a perfectly good approval link, and then charges the template's placeholder price of 1.00 a month.

So the code reads the plan back off PayPal after creating it, compares every payment against what it calculated, and refuses to hand over the approval link if they differ. The customer sees an error instead of a plan. Nothing has been charged at that point.

9. The things you would have asked on a call

- Why not just use a subscriptions plugin?

Because none of them do this. Off-the-shelf subscription plugins sell a fixed product at a fixed price forever. You need an arbitrary balance split over a term the customer picks, stopping on its own. Your brief also specifically asked for the REST API rather than a plugin, and that turned out to be the right call.

- Where does the money go?

Straight into your PayPal account, on your PayPal app, under your own Developer credentials. Nothing routes through me. I never hold your credentials beyond the sandbox testing, and the live ones go into your `wp-config.php`, not into anything of mine.

- How does the customer get their link?

You copy it off the detail screen and send it however you already talk to them — email, WhatsApp, on an invoice. Anyone holding the link can set that one plan up, so treat it exactly like an emailed invoice link. It exposes that single balance and nothing else: no other customer, no list, no account.

- What if a payment fails?

PayPal retries on its own schedule. The plan shows as `payment_failed` on your screen and clears itself when a charge succeeds. If the retries run out and the plan ends with money still owed, it is flagged `ended_short` — the one status worth watching, because it means a human needs to make a phone call.

- Can the customer pay it off early?

Not through this page as built. PayPal subscriptions bill on a schedule; there is no "settle the rest now" button in them. If you want that it is a separate one-off payment button that cancels the plan on success — a small addition, but an addition, so say the word and I will scope it rather than quietly assume it.

- What happens if the plugin is removed?

Payment history stays. Uninstalling deliberately does not drop the two database tables, because a record of who paid you what should outlive a plugin folder. Subscriptions already running at PayPal also keep running — they live at PayPal, not on your site.

- Can two people set up the same plan twice?

No. The term is checked server-side against what that specific customer was offered, so editing the request gets a 400 rather than a cheaper plan. Each attempt carries an idempotency key, repeat webhook deliveries are rejected by a unique index on PayPal's sale id, and paid-to-date is recalculated from the ledger rather than added to — so a replayed message cannot double-count.

- Who owns the code?

You do. It is in a private repository and I will add you as a collaborator whenever you send me a GitHub username; the full source is also in the zip in our chat. No licence key, no phone-home, no dependency on me being around. It is plain PHP with no third-party libraries at all.

- Why won't you get on a call?

Straight answer: I work text-only here on Freelancer — no phone, no video, no screen share. It is a hard limit on how I work, not a preference. If that is a dealbreaker for you I would rather know now than waste your time. What I can do is what this page is: write it down, in detail, with the screens attached, so nothing depends on either of us remembering what was said.

Written for the Freelancer project “PayPal Flexible Payment Portal & Subscription Setup”. Anything here that turns out to be wrong, tell me in the chat and I will correct the page rather than argue about what was agreed.